

Check Writing & Budgeting Exercise

Facilitator:

Suggested time: 20-30 minutes

Materials: Activity instructions, Slides, copies of example checks, copies of example check balancing sheets; whiteboard, markers and pens; large envelopes with expense items, prices, and instructions; chocolate coins (if in-person, optional), calculators.

Activity:

The following activity is optional, depending on time and funds available, and will require a fair amount of preparation by the facilitators in advance. The purpose of this exercise is to give participants an opportunity to practice their skills in check-writing, balancing a checkbook, and budgeting/making sound financial decisions. It will also make the class more interactive and fun. The PowerPoint slides explain the activity and have instructions for the participants.

Instructions:

Step 1: Prepare Envelopes and Practice Checks

- If you are facilitating class in-person, one facilitator will pass out six example checks and an example check balancing sheet (located in the activity instructions) to each participant, as well as calculators. If you are facilitating online, send out virtual example checks and a virtual check balancing sheet that participants can edit on their computers.
- While one facilitator is doing this, the other will set up the envelopes, which will contain an expense item that falls under one of three categories: *housing, transportation, and wellness*.
 - Each expense item will be on a printed out card, or will be projected on the PowerPoint slides (depending if you're teaching in-person or virtually, and whether you want a paper-less option). Each of these options has a specific number of points associated with it (see the options in this Guide). Participants will "go shopping," using their example checks for one of each expense item.
 - If facilitating class in-person, the points will be located on the back of each card. If facilitating class online, facilitators will keep track of the points associated with each option, using the Facilitator Guide.

- If in-person, the facilitators will place the envelopes front-side up across the tables so everyone can see, making sure the envelopes stay grouped in their respective categories. You can spread the envelopes out on different tables in the room to encourage participants to walk about and “go shopping.”
 - If time and available funds permit, you can purchase chocolate coins to use instead of tallying up points at the end. If you decide to do this, you will place the chocolate coins (10-20, depending on class size) in each envelope prior to the class.
- If you are facilitating online, the activity will follow the same structure, but instead of moving around the room to select housing, transportation, and wellness options from the envelopes provided, participants will choose from the options in the PowerPoint slides and write their sample checks on their computers using virtual copies.
 - The options will still have different points associated with them, and participants will still tally up their points at the end.
- On the whiteboard, one facilitator will write three typical expenses: power, cable, and credit bills. These expenses are also on the PowerPoint slides for this workshop.

Step 2: Go Shopping

- Give everyone a starting amount of \$3000. This is their monthly salary that they have to work with. Their job is to pay their bills, then find a place to live, a way to get around, and something that will bring them joy.
- Ask the participants to first pay the bills listed on the whiteboard and/or slides, using their sample checks. Once these basic bills have been paid, invite the participants to look through the items presented on the table/on the screen and “go shopping.” Instruct everyone to pick one item from each category (housing, transportation, and wellness).
- Once everyone has written checks for their selected items and entered the information into their check balancing sheets, ask the participants to turn the envelopes of their selected items over and follow the instructions for how many points (or coins) to collect. If facilitating online, facilitators will let the participants know how many points are associated with each of the items they chose.
- After everyone has tallied up their points, invite the participants to share their thoughts and experiences with this exercise and how many points they were able to collect. Ask if they noticed the correlation between their expense choices and the amount of points they were able to collect.